

The Phoenicians

From their homeland on the coast of what is now Lebanon and parts of Syria and Israel, the Phoenicians became the leading seafaring merchants of the ancient world. From the 10th century BCE, they sailed the Mediterranean, searching for new markets, founding colonies, and spreading their culture, including their language and alphabet.

The Phoenicians lived in around a dozen coastal cities, including Byblos, Tyre, and Sidon, each of which was ruled by a king. The hills of their homeland were covered with tall cedar trees, which the Phoenicians used to build their ships. They also sold the cedar wood to Egypt, Greece, and Mesopotamia.

The Phoenicians founded trading stations across the Mediterranean, such as Carthage in North Africa. They also explored the Atlantic

coast of Europe, the Indian Ocean and—according to one ancient historian—in c. 500 BCE, sailed around Africa, in search of new markets.

Phoenician cities were centers of fine craftwork, producing glassware, metalwork, textiles, and furniture decorated with ivory. Phoenician traders exchanged these for products not available in their cities, such as tin and silver from Spain, copper from Cyprus, incense from Arabia, and ivory from Egypt.

▼ PHOENICIAN CRAFTS

Phoenician crafts were influenced by the different cultures they encountered. This Phoenician carved ivory panel, found in present-day Iraq, combines an Egyptian sphinx and a Mesopotamian lamassu (a human-headed winged lion).



The sphinx wears a striped headcloth as worn by Egyptian pharaohs.



▲ PHOENICIAN BIREME

The Phoenicians used their cedar to build warships. Their standard warship was a bireme—a ship powered by two decks of oars. The Persian Empire's navy was made up of Phoenician ships.



▲ TYRIAN PURPLE

The Phoenician city of Tyre was famous for a purple dye made from the shells of a Murex sea snail. It took tens of thousands of snails to make a small amount of this dye, which came to be known as Tyrian purple. Cloth dyed with Tyrian purple was highly valued, and was worn mostly by kings and emperors.

Phoenician script, from a temple in Cyprus



▲ PHOENICIAN ALPHABET

Unlike Mesopotamian or Egyptian scripts that had hundreds of signs, the Phoenician alphabet had just 22, all standing for consonants. Easy to learn, it was adapted by the Greeks, who added vowel signs, and then later by the Romans.